

Study Scenarios — Overview for IRB Review (All Variations)

Measuring and Improving Relational Fluency with Simulated Online Encounters

Simulated Encounters | PI: Rene Kizilcec | IRB0151104

Each participant completes four short, voice-based conversations with adaptive AI conversation partners, one for each of four interpersonal skills drawn from the Emotional and Social Competency Inventory (ESCI) Relationship-Management cluster. Scenarios depict ordinary workplace situations. The AI partners play realistic coworkers, managers, or teammates and adapt to what the participant says. Each conversation opens with a fixed prompt for comparability and then unfolds freely; each contains several “pressure points” where the target skill can be demonstrated. Surface details (names, industry, channel) are randomized across participants. This document presents every variation of each scenario in full; each participant experiences one variation per scenario. Assignment rule: because Scenario 4 always involves misattributed credit, participants receive Scenario 1 in Variation B or C within the same session, so the Conflict Management and Teamwork measures do not overlap in content. No real people, real workplaces, or personal disputes of the participant are involved; all counterparts are simulated.

Content note for reviewers: scenarios involve mild interpersonal tension typical of everyday work (e.g., an unfair-seeming rule, a hostile after-hours message, a colleague taking credit). They do not involve harassment, abuse, or content of a sensitive or explicit nature, and participants may skip or stop at any time.

Scenario 1 Conflict Management

Skill measured: Bringing disagreement into the open, de-escalating emotion, and resolving rather than avoiding conflict.

Duration: ~7–12 minutes (one variation per participant)

Key decision points (shared by all variations — where the skill can be shown or missed):

- Whether to send a retaliatory message, refuse it, or redirect to a direct conversation
- How to raise the issue plainly without accusation
- How to respond when the peer becomes defensive
- Whether to widen the audience or keep it between the parties
- How to handle a partial, face-saving concession

Variation A — Taken credit

The situation: A peer has repeatedly presented the participant's work as their own despite polite requests to stop, and a colleague is urging a public, sarcastic call-out. (Per the assignment rule, this variation is not used in sessions that include Scenario 4.)

What the participant does: Talks through the situation with the AI colleague who is pushing for retaliation, then takes part in a live conversation with the peer, deciding how to raise the issue and how to respond to a defensive reaction and a partial concession.

Variation B — Hostile after-hours message

The situation: Late the previous evening, a peer sent the participant an aggressive message about a shared deliverable, copying two teammates. A colleague is urging an equally sharp reply-all in return.

What the participant does: Decides how to respond to the message and to the colleague urging escalation, then holds a direct conversation with the peer the next morning to address both the substance of the complaint and the way it was delivered.

Variation C — Public blame

The situation: In a meeting with the manager present, a peer blamed the participant for a mistake that was demonstrably shared. A colleague is urging the participant to correct the record just as publicly.

What the participant does: Chooses between public correction and a private conversation, then talks with the peer directly — working through the peer's defensiveness toward an account of the mistake both can stand behind, and deciding what, if anything, to say to the manager.

Scenario 2 Influence

Skill measured: Persuading by anticipating objections, using multiple strategies, and appealing to others' interests.

Duration: ~7–12 minutes (one variation per participant)

Key decision points (shared by all variations — where the skill can be shown or missed):

- Opening as a demand versus a reasoned case
- Switching strategies when one is deflected (“next cycle,” “hands tied”)
- Framing the leverage as shared problem-solving versus a threat
- Equipping the manager to make the case upward
- Securing concrete commitments while keeping the relationship intact

Variation A — Promised raise and a competing offer

The situation: The participant was promised a raise that never came while their workload grew; they now hold a written competing offer at meaningfully higher pay and meet a sympathetic but budget-constrained manager.

What the participant does: Prepares a case and has a negotiation conversation with the AI manager, who deploys realistic deflections; decides when and how to surface the competing offer, and works toward a concrete, dated commitment.

Variation B — Hybrid arrangement under a return-to-office mandate

The situation: A company-wide return-to-office push threatens the participant's long-standing, high-performing two-days-remote arrangement. The manager is not personally opposed but is under pressure from above; another team has kept hybrid by presenting a productivity case.

What the participant does: Makes the case for preserving the arrangement in a meeting with the AI manager — marshaling their record, the other team's precedent, and proposals (such as a reviewable trial) the manager can defend to the director.

Variation C — Resources for an overloaded team

The situation: Six months ago the participant's team “temporarily” absorbed a departed colleague's workload. Nothing has changed, attrition risk is growing, and the participant meets the manager with a concrete backfill proposal.

What the participant does: Presents the case for relief or backfill to the AI manager, responds to budget deflections by adjusting strategy, and works toward a committed next step — an approved requisition, interim relief, or a dated decision point.

Scenario 3 Inspirational Leadership

Skill measured: Articulating a credible vision, building group pride, and bringing out others' best.

Duration: ~7–12 minutes (one variation per participant)

Key decision points (shared by all variations — where the skill can be shown or missed):

- Delivering an honest message versus spin
- Handling a cynical member's public challenge
- Noticing and re-engaging a disengaged high performer
- Building credible pride in the team's work
- Making few, specific commitments and following through

Variation A — After resignations over a pay dispute

The situation: As interim team lead after two colleagues resigned over pay, the participant must lead a demoralized three-person team through a quarter with no new resources; leadership above declines to discuss compensation.

What the participant does: Reviews short 1:1 notes, then leads a simulated team meeting and brief one-on-ones with AI team members in different emotional states — a vocal cynic, a quietly disengaged high performer, and an anxious junior.

Variation B — After a commission restructuring

The situation: A commission restructuring, decided two levels up, has cut take-home pay for the team's strongest performers. The participant leads the team through the aftermath with no authority to reverse the decision.

What the participant does: Leads the team meeting and one-on-ones, deciding how honestly to characterize the change, how to respond to public cynicism, and what they can credibly offer — advocacy upward, ownership, visibility — to re-engage the team's best people.

Variation C — Rolling out an unpopular mandated change

The situation: Head office has mandated a new scheduling and workflow system the team is convinced will fail. The mandate is fixed, but implementation details are local, and the team's veteran opinion leader is openly skeptical.

What the participant does: Leads the rollout conversation — separating the non-negotiable from the co-designable, mining the veteran's experience of past failures, and converting skeptics into co-owners of the implementation.

Scenario 4 Teamwork

Skill measured: Cooperating, soliciting input, sharing credit, and encouraging everyone's participation.

Duration: ~7–12 minutes (one variation per participant)

Key decision points (shared by all variations — where the skill can be shown or missed):

- Noticing the exclusion without being told
- Retrieving an interrupted contribution
- Addressing misattributed credit without humiliating anyone
- Soliciting input from quiet members before decisions close
- Allocating visible, credited work fairly at the end

Variation A — Planning an internal rollout

The situation: In a four-person group task planning the rollout of a new internal process, one AI teammate is quietly excluded — despite holding a critical insight about a previous rollout's failure — and another dominates, restating others' ideas as their own.

What the participant does: Participates in the group working session, choosing how to include the excluded member, retrieve their interrupted contribution, handle the credit imbalance respectfully, and allocate named pieces of the final plan fairly.

Variation B — Preparing a client presentation

The situation: The group is preparing a client-facing presentation. The excluded teammate is the only one who understands the client's actual priorities; the dominant teammate has arrived with a pre-built deck and a plan to present it alone.

What the participant does: Works with the group to shape the presentation, drawing out the excluded member's client knowledge, rebalancing speaking roles, and ensuring the final materials credit contributors accurately.

Variation C — Triageing a shared backlog

The situation: The group must prioritize a shared project backlog. The excluded teammate knows about a dependency that reorders everything; the dominant teammate is pushing their own ranking through and restating others' points as their own.

What the participant does: Participates in the triage session, noticing and retrieving the dependency insight, addressing the idea laundering without humiliation, and closing with a prioritization and division of labor everyone actively endorses.

How scenarios are scored

Trained raters (not the participants) review the recorded encounters and score each skill using behaviorally anchored ESCI items on a 1–5 frequency scale (Never to Consistently), aggregating across the pressure points. All variations of a scenario are scored with the same items and decision points, so scores are comparable across variations. See the companion document, “Study Measures — Overview for IRB Review,” for the full item list.